

Stalactite

These hang down like icicles. They form in the same way as stalagmites, from rocky particles dissolved in water, this time dripping from the cave's ceiling.

Soda straws

These thin, hollow tubes also form from dissolved particles in water, dripping slowly through the roof of a cave. They may grow into stalactites if the water keeps dripping for a very long time.

Column

If a stalagmite and stalactite become long enough and meet, they will form a rocky column. Columns are also created when a stalactite grows down to touch the cave floor.



Skaftafell cave, Iceland



Benagil cave, Portugal

Ice caves

Ice melting on top of a glacier can form a stream or waterfall that flows through the glacier. Eventually, this flowing water will hollow out part of the glacier, creating an ice cave.

Sea caves

These are formed by waves constantly battering against cliffs along the seashore. This leads to cracks appearing in the cliffs that get larger as beating waves continue to wear away the rock.